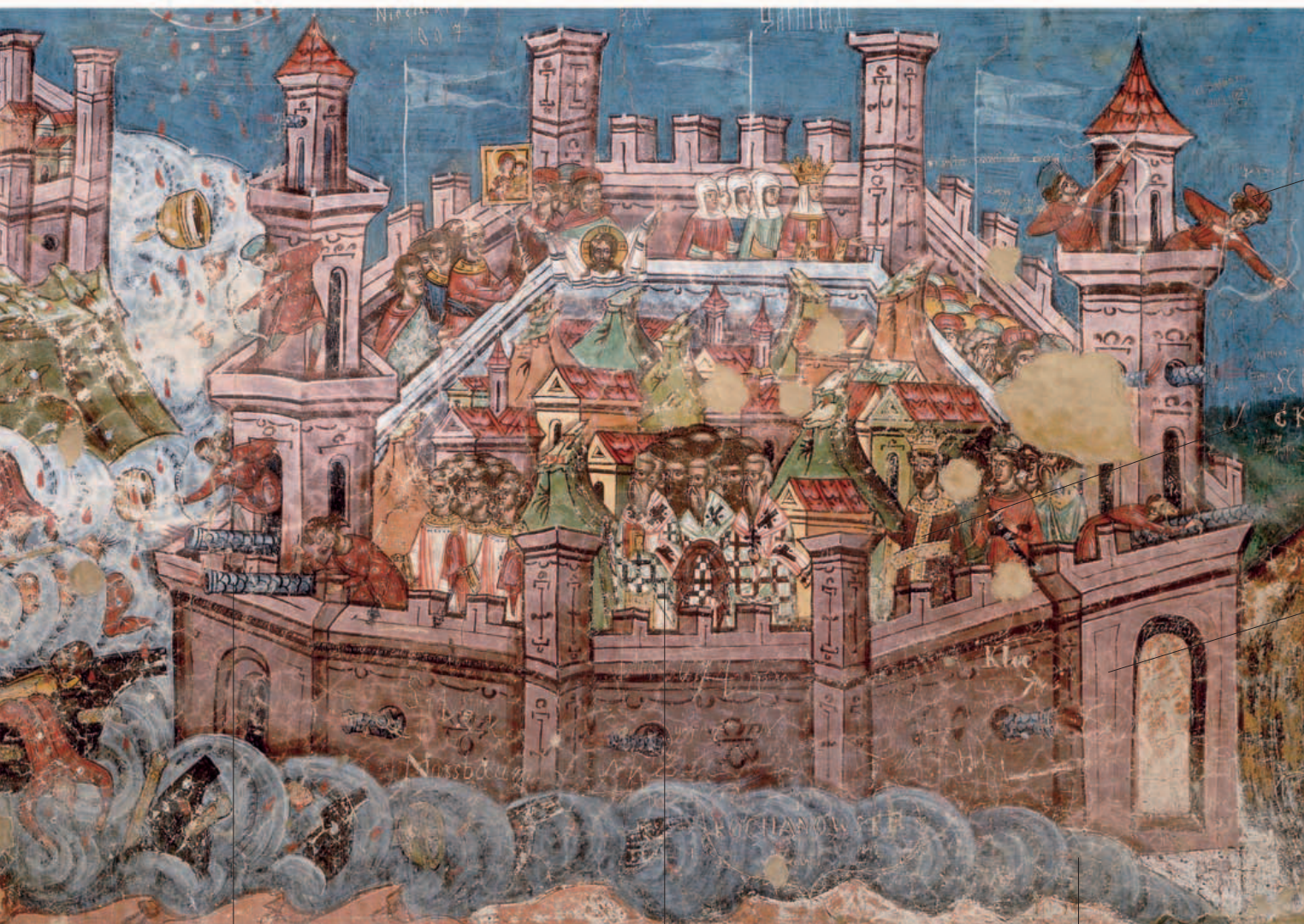




High towers aided the defenders. The Ottomans used siege towers to try to get the attackers to the same height, but these were also repelled.

Constantine XI Palaeologus, the last reigning Byzantine emperor, personally led the final defense of the city and died in the final attack.

The city walls withstood numerous assaults before being breached. The Ottomans tried to mine under the walls, but were thwarted each time.

The Siege of Constantinople

This 16th-century fresco shows the 1453 siege of Constantinople. The Ottomans had besieged Constantinople twice before but failed each time. Three days of looting followed its fall on May 29, 1453, and Sultan Mehmed II, who led the attack, spent much of the rest of his reign restoring and repopulating the city.

Ottoman artillery was far superior to Byzantine artillery. Huge cannons eventually breached the city walls, allowing them to enter.

Hagia Sophia Church in Constantinople was converted into a mosque immediately after the capture of the city.

The waters of the Bosphorus protect Constantinople. Mehmet II fortified castles on either side of the Bosphorus to prevent reinforcements.

AFTER

OTTOMAN SULTAN (1432–81)

MEHMED II

Mehmed II was sultan of the Ottoman Empire from 1451 to 1481. This 15th-century watercolor shows him in a peaceful pose. The reality was very different. One of Mehmed's first acts as sultan was to have his infant brother strangled to prevent further civil wars. His reign was one of ceaseless campaigning, which extended the empire to include most of the Balkans and Greece, Anatolia, the upper Euphrates valley, and sections of the Black Sea coast.



Later wars with Hungary, which was threatened by Ottoman expansion, led to the adoption of artillery-based military tactics. It was this development that made the Ottoman conquest of Constantinople possible.

Attacks by a neighboring principality in Anatolia in 1397 forced the Ottomans to take action, resulting in the conquest of most of eastern Anatolia. This bordered on the territory of the Mongol warlord Timur, whose empire stretched across Central Asia, southern Russia, Iran, and Azerbaijan. In 1402, Timur invaded Anatolia, capturing Bayezid, the Ottoman leader, and plundered Anatolia for a year. The remaining small portion of Anatolian territory, and Ottoman lands in Europe, were split between the sons of Bayezid. Civil war ensued for two

generations. The eventual winner, Murad II, spent most of his life fighting to restore the lands the Ottomans had lost to Timur and securing his borders. He abdicated in 1444 in favor of his 12-year old son, but was recalled by his viziers (ministers) when the king of Hungary attacked the empire. At Murad's death in 1451, the Ottoman Empire dominated western and northern Anatolia and a large part of the Balkans.

Murad was succeeded by one of the Ottoman Empire's most able leaders, Mehmed II (see left). After securing his borders, he laid siege to the city of Constantinople in 1453. Just 50 years after the near destruction of the Ottomans, despite civil war and in-fighting, they captured a wealthy imperial city, and brought down the remains of the Byzantine Empire.



Fritware pottery
Produced in the Middle East in the 13th century, fritware combined ground glass with clay to produce white ceramics.

The Ottoman Empire continued to be a preeminent cultural and military power into the 17th century and beyond.



IZNIK POTTERY

IZNIK POTTERY

Iznik pottery became popular in the 16th century. Under sultans such as Suleyman the Magnificent (1520–66), the Ottomans enjoyed a golden age of cultural development **246–47** >>.

THE JANISSARIES

Originally the sultan's household infantry, the Ottoman Empire used the janissaries in all its **major campaigns** of the 16th–17th centuries **246–47** >>. By the 18th century the janissaries even dominated government. After revolting in 1826, they were abolished.

JANISSARY

